Familiarization, Internalization, Articulation (FIA) Translation Guide © 2025 Word Collective Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 license. Familiarization, Internalization, Articulation (FIA) Translation Guide has been adapted in the following languages Tok Pisin, عربي, Français, हिंदी, Bahasa Indonesia, Português, Русский, Español, Kiswahili, 简体中文 from Familiarization, Internalization, Articulation (FIA) © 2025 Word Collective Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 license by Mission Mutual

3 John 1:1–8

3 John

3 John 1:1–8

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 3 John verses 1 to 8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 1 to 8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 1 to 8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This book is a letter. In this passage, we find out who is writing the letter and to whom.

The writer calls himself “the elder,” and he does not give his name. This means that the writer’s listeners would have understood who “the elder” was. There was no need to say his name. An elder can mean someone who is older than most other people, but it can also be a title for someone in the church who has authority. Since we assume that the writer of this letter is the Apostle John, we can say that the elder was John. John was probably a very old man by now, and the only one of the apostles who was still alive. There are many believers and many churches in different places, but John is the only one who is still alive who has seen Jesus when Jesus was on earth.

The elder is writing to Gaius. We do not know who Gaius was or where he lived. We hear about a person named Gaius in the book of Acts and in Romans, but Gaius was a common name, so these people were probably different people. However, we understand from this letter that Gaius was a believer. We hear good things about Gaius. John loves Gaius. Gaius is believing the right things and is behaving in the right way. Gaius receives traveling preachers in his home, even if they are strangers to him. John has heard these good things about Gaius, probably from some traveling preachers who had stayed with Gaius.

Stop here and discuss: In your community, what are the rules for receiving guests? Who can come to your house and expect that you will receive them? Who can not expect to stay with you? What will happen if you do, or do not, let people stay with you? What kind of things do guests expect you to do for them? Pause this audio here.

John encourages Gaius to keep doing this good thing, to keep receiving in his house and helping the traveling preachers. Even more so, John asks Gaius to give these traveling preachers what they need to continue their journey. We now understand that these traveling preachers are what we now often call missionaries. These traveling missionaries do not get any salary. These missionaries need the believers in the different churches to help them. The missionaries would need food and a place to stay, and some money for traveling. John asks Gaius to generously help any traveling missionaries who come to him in this way. This way, John says, Gaius himself helps to spread the good news about Jesus.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about how your church helps a missionary or supports a preacher? Pause this audio here.

John says that these traveling preachers do not take any money from nonbelievers. It was quite common in John’s time for religious preachers to travel around and to beg for money. Some people had even gotten quite

3 John 1:1–8

rich because of this! But Christians should not do this. The gospel is not something that we sell to the people, but something that we freely share, without expecting anything in return! And so, these traveling preachers need other believers to help them, so that they have enough to do their work.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about religious preachers or travelers who ask money from other people?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 1 to 8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: The elder greets Gaius.

In the second part: The elder says how happy he is that Gaius is believing and doing the right things.

In the third part: John asks Gaius to continue to support traveling preachers.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself "the elder"
- Gaius
- Some traveling preachers
- Christ
- And non-believers

The "elder," John, calls Gaius "beloved." This means that John loves Gaius. It can also mean that God loves Gaius. Both would be true!

John says that he loves Gaius in "the truth." This probably means that John loves Gaius because both John and Gaius believe in the true message of God. John said the same thing in his previous letter to the "lady and her children."

John does not love Gaius in a romantic way, but John loves Gaius in the way that every believer should love each other. When believers love each other, they are kind to each other, and they want what is best for the other. Believers do not look down on each other. Believers help each other and do good things for each other, even if it is inconvenient for them.

John hopes that Gaius is doing well and is healthy. This was a normal and polite way for people to begin a letter.

John already knows that Gaius' soul is well; this means Gaius is doing well spiritually. John hopes that Gaius will do just as well in any other aspect of his life.

Stop here and discuss how you will begin this letter. Pause this audio here.

We then find out that some believers had given John news about Gaius. John calls these believers "brothers." All believers are brothers and sisters with each other because they are all children of God. These believers were probably traveling preachers or missionaries, and John might have been the one who had sent them. These traveling preachers had visited Gaius.

John heard from these traveling preachers that Gaius was faithful to the truth. When John speaks about the truth, John means the true message that God has given the people. The idea of "truth" is, for John, another way to talk about the gospel message. Someone who is faithful to the truth keeps believing the right things, the true message from God. And Gaius is walking in the truth. In the previous letter from John, we have learned that a person who walks in the truth is someone who believes the right things about Jesus, who obeys God, and who loves the other believers.

3 John 1:1–8

John says that nothing makes him more glad than to hear that his children are walking in the truth. John thinks about Gaius as one of his children. Gaius is not really a child of John, but Gaius might have learned about Jesus from John. John is the spiritual father of Gaius.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who was a spiritual father or mother for you? Pause this audio here.

Gaius has shown that he is faithful to the truth—that he is believing and doing the right things—by helping the traveling preachers. This probably means that Gaius has shown hospitality to the traveling preachers who had come from John. These are the same people who then told John about Gaius. It seems that Gaius did not know these people at first. These people were strangers to Gaius, but he still welcomed them and helped them because they came from John.

In Gaius' culture, it might have been quite normal to give hospitality to people whom you knew. But Gaius is doing more than that. Gaius even gives hospitality to people that he does not know! This was probably quite unusual in Gaius' culture.

When these traveling preachers came back to John, they told about Gaius in front of all the believers in John's church. They told everybody that Gaius had shown the traveling preachers love. Gaius had done good things for the preachers.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that John sends some traveling preachers to do their work. Act out that these traveling preachers come to Gaius' house and ask if they can stay overnight at his house. Act out that Gaius does not know these preachers, but still welcomes them. Act out that the traveling preachers continue with their journey and tell people about Jesus on the way. Act out that the preachers come back to John's church, and that they tell the people what happened. Act out that the preachers tell good things about Gaius. You can act out that John is very happy when he hears all this. Pause this audio here.

John asks Gaius to keep doing these good things. The next time, when traveling preachers come to Gaius, Gaius should help these people again. John says that Gaius will do well to help the brothers. This is a polite way to ask Gaius to do this. John asks Gaius to send the brothers on their journey in a manner that is worthy of God. This means that Gaius should give these traveling preachers what they need in order to continue their work as traveling preachers. When believers are helping each other, this honors God. God is glad when believers are helping each other.

It is important to help the traveling preachers because they are working on behalf of "the Name." The name refers to Christ. John means that these preachers are working for Christ.

These preachers do not take money or help from nonbelievers. Therefore, it is the responsibility of the other believers to help these preachers. And when believers are helping preachers and missionaries to do their work, then the believers themselves are also helping the work of God. John says that they then share in the truth. John means that they are sharing in the work of giving people the true message from God.

Stop here and do this activity: Find something that is heavy, such as a bag with lots of things in it, a rock, a bucket of water, or anything that you can find. Ask one person to carry this heavy thing over some distance. Decide together where that person should take this object. While that person is carrying the object, everybody else will do some things to help this person. The people will give that person water or some food, or they will take away some obstacle on the road. You can act this out or use real food and things. When the person has reached the end, everybody will celebrate. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, only one person was carrying the weight, but the other people were helping the person by giving him what he needed. In the end, everybody celebrated. Everybody had been part of bringing the object to the other place. In the same way, everybody who helps preachers, missionaries, pastors, and other people to do special work for God becomes part of this special work as well.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 1 to 8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

3 John 1:1–8

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself “the elder”
- Gaius
- Some traveling preachers
- Christ
- And non-believers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is speaking to Gaius. Of course, John is far away from Gaius and cannot see Gaius as John writes. But when we act this out as if John is speaking directly to Gaius, it will help us to understand the letter better.

John says something like this:

“From the old man, to dear Gaius. I love you because we both believe God’s true message.

“Dear Gaius, I hope that you are doing well, in body and in spirit. I know that you are doing well in spirit because I just heard good news about you! Some of the believers who are traveling around to teach other believers had visited you. When these believers came back, they told me that you are believing and obeying God’s true message. This made me so glad! Anytime that I hear that one of my children is living according to God’s true message, I am overjoyed.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Gaius, “What are you thinking?” People may answer things like:

- I am very glad to get a letter from John! I wonder what John wants to tell me; or
- I feel so good that people have told good things about me to John! I am glad that John is happy about what I have done. I feel very honored.

Resume the drama. John says something like this:

“Dear Gaius, I heard that you are doing much good for traveling preachers such as these people. You are helping such preachers even if they are strangers to you! By doing this, you show them that you love them. My friends have told me and the others in our church all about that.

I encourage you to keep doing this. When traveling preachers come to visit you, please give them what they need to continue their journey. When you do this, God will be glad.

“These preachers are traveling because Christ wants them to do this. These preachers do not take any help from nonbelievers. And so it is important that we support them. When we do this, then we are helping more people to hear God’s true message.” Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Gaius, “What are you thinking?” People may answer things like:

- I am glad that John asks me to help the traveling preachers. I am really glad that in this way I can help more people to hear God’s true message; or
- I feel quite honored that John asks me to do this!

3 John 1:1–8

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 1 to 8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This book is a letter from someone who calls himself "the elder." An elder means an old person. Someone who is old has more experience and authority than a younger person. Therefore, over time, people began to use the word "elder" for someone with authority in the church, like a pastor or leader.

John says he is "the elder" because this must have been what people called John. There might be many elders, but John was the most important one.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that this is a letter from **the elder**. Use the same word for elder as you used when you translated 2 John. Elder is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John begins this part by calling Gaius "**beloved**." This means that John loves Gaius. It can also mean that God loves Gaius. Both would be true! In your translation, you want to use a word that a respected senior leader could use when addressing other people very kindly. In the first book of John, his sermon, John also addressed his listeners as beloved. Use the same word as you have used there.

Stop here and discuss how you would like John to address Gaius here. Pause this audio here.

John wishes that Gaius is well. Some translations say that John "prays" that Gaius is well. John is using the normal way to begin a letter. John expresses politely that he hopes that Gaius is well.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that John **wishes** that Gaius is well. If you want to say that John "prays that Gaius is well," you may refer to **pray** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

John wishes that Gaius is doing well in all aspects of life. John also hopes that Gaius is healthy. Again, John is using a normal, polite way to start a letter. John already knows that Gaius is doing well spiritually. Some translations say that Gaius is doing well in his soul. This means the same thing. It means that Gaius has a good relationship with God. John hopes that Gaius is doing just as well physically as he is doing spiritually.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that John hopes that Gaius is doing well, and that he hopes Gaius is healthy, just as Gaius is doing **spiritually** well. If you want to use the word for **soul**, you can listen to the explanation in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John was overjoyed when some of the brothers came and told John about Gaius. When you are overjoyed, you are very happy. "The brothers" refers to believers, and probably especially, to traveling preachers.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you want to use for **brothers** here. You may choose to use the same word for brothers here that you used in 1 John. Pause this audio here.

The brothers testified that Gaius was faithful to the truth. If you testify, you tell something that you have seen yourself that is true. Gaius was faithful to the truth. This means that Gaius is believing God's true message and is living according to God's message. Gaius is believing and doing the right things.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the brothers **testified** that Gaius was **faithful to the truth**. The word testimony is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Gaius walks in the truth. This means that Gaius continuously believes and does the right things.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Gaius **walks in the truth**. Use the same words as you used when you were translating 2 John. Pause this audio here.

John is most happy when he hears that his children walk in the truth. In the previous books, we also saw that John often calls his listeners children. John loves the believers as a father loves his children. John is a spiritual father of Gaius.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that John is happy when **his children** walk in the truth. Pause this audio here.

3 John 1:1–8

The traveling teachers told the church about Gaius' love. In the Bible, people never use the word church to mean a building. Instead, the church is a community of people who believe in Jesus. The people who belong to the church come together regularly to pray, to worship God, to celebrate the Lord's supper, and to study God's word together.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **church**. Pause this audio here.

The brothers went out for the sake of his Name. John uses the phrase "going out" as a way to describe the work of evangelists and missionaries. John used the same word when he was talking about the false teachers in his previous letter. In that letter, John said that many false teachers had gone out into the world.

The brothers go out for the sake of "his Name." "His Name" refers to **Christ's name**, or to God's name, or both. This means that the brothers are traveling with the purpose to tell other people about Christ.

Christ means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that "the brothers," or the traveling preachers, are **going out** for the **sake of his Name**, or for the sake of Christ's name, or for the sake of Christ. Pause this audio here.

The traveling preachers did not accept anything from unbelievers. This means the preachers did not ask for or accept payment from unbelievers when they shared with them the gospel, God's true message. "Unbelievers" refers to people who do not know or accept the good news that Jesus died to save people.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that the traveling preachers did not accept anything from unbelievers. Pause this audio here.

John says that we should support traveling preachers and missionaries. If we do that, John says that we become coworkers with the truth. We are helping the traveling preachers, or the missionaries, to tell God's true message to other people. By doing this, it is as if we are missionaries ourselves.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that we should support such people, so that we become coworkers with these people in sharing God's true message.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one part but you liked the way a different group member told another part.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

3 John 1:1–8

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (704 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (996 KB)

3 John 1:9–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 3 John verses 9 to 10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 9 to 10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 9 to 10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John was very glad that Gaius was believing and doing the right things. In this part of the letter, we meet a man named Diotrephes. John is not at all happy about Diotrephes! It seems that Diotrephes was a member of a particular church. Diotrephes had a lot of influence over the people in his church. Maybe Diotrephes was the leader of the church, but at the very least, he wanted to be the leader over this church.

John says that John had written a letter to this particular church. John does not say what he wrote in that letter. It is quite possible that John had sent this letter with some traveling preachers, and in the letter, John had asked the people in this church to welcome these traveling preachers, to let them stay in their house and to help them in any way.

But Diotrephes did not want to listen to John. Diotrephes did not want to do what John asked him to do in John's letter.

Stop here and discuss: In your church, is there someone who has authority over the pastor or other local leaders of the church? Maybe a bishop, or a leader over several churches? If this person would ask the leader of your local church to do something, but the local leader would refuse, what would happen? How would this person with the greater authority feel? What might they do? Pause this audio here.

Maybe John's letter had first come to Diotrephes, and Diotrephes did not share the letter with the other members in his church. Or, all the people in the church did hear the letter, but Diotrephes convinced the people that they should not listen to John. It seems that some people disagreed with Diotrephes. These people did want to listen to John. These people did want to give hospitality to the traveling preachers who had come from John. But Diotrephes did not allow the people to do this. It seems that Diotrephes had a lot of power in his church. Diotrephes wanted to control everything.

3 John 1:9–10

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about some powerful people who have much influence over other believers? What would happen if someone disagreed with such a powerful person in the church? Pause this audio here.

Diotrephes told the people at his church lies about John. Diotrephes even removed some people from the church. This means that Diotrephes did not allow these people to keep coming to their meetings. Diotrephes did not allow these people to remain part of their community of believers. Diotrephes removed these people from the church because these people wanted to give hospitality to the traveling preachers who had come from John. Diotrephes did not show love to John, nor to the traveling preachers, nor to the people in his own church.

This must have been a very sad situation! The people who had become believers probably already had suffered when they became believers. These people might have lost their family and their community when they became believers. The church became these people's new family and their new community. But now there is conflict within this new community! Can you imagine how difficult the situation must have been for them?

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a painful conflict in the church, which caused the church to split? Pause this audio here.

Unfortunately, some of you probably had a painful story to tell. Conflicts still happen in churches today as well. That is why it is so important that we keep listening to Jesus' command that we should love each other! If you did not have a painful story to tell, then let us praise God for that!

Stop here and do this activity: Let us pray together for unity in our church and in the churches all over the world. Let us pray that we will all obey Jesus and love each other. Let us thank God for the churches where people do love each other!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 9 to 10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part. In this part, John speaks about what Diotrephes has done.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself "the elder"
- Gaius
- Some traveling preachers
- Diotrephes
- And people in Diotrephes' church

John says that he had written something to the church. This means that John wrote a letter to the people in the church that Diotrephes belonged to.

Diotrephes did not want to listen to John. Diotrephes does not accept that John has authority over him and his church. Diotrephes thinks that he himself is very important. Diotrephes behaves as if he is the leader of the church.

John tells Gaius that he, John, will come and will tell the people what Diotrephes has done. John probably means that John will tell these things to the people in Gaius' church. If Gaius' church is nearby Diotrephes' church, then it might be important to warn the people in Gaius' church against Diotrephes.

We mentioned earlier that some scholars think that Gaius might have been a member of the same church as Diotrephes. But somehow, Gaius had stayed out of the conflict so far; maybe because he lived quite far away. If this is the case, then John might mean that when John will come, he will tell the people in Diotrephes' church what Diotrephes had done. Maybe not everybody in the church knew what had happened. Or, maybe John hopes that when he speaks to the people in the church, people who had chosen the side of Diotrephes will see that Diotrephes was wrong, and they will again accept John's authority.

3 John 1:9–10

Diotrephes had told lies about John. We do not know what Diotrephes had said about John. Diotrephes told lies about John, so that other people would no longer respect John. But John says that these lies are evil and that they are nonsense. It is as if Diotrephes was just babbling.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about how someone told lies about some else and harmed that person's relationships? Pay attention to the way you talk about someone who is telling lies about other people. Pause this audio here.

Diotrephes did not just tell lies about John. Diotrephes did other things that were even worse. Diotrephes did not show hospitality to the traveling teachers. Diotrephes did not allow other people in the church to help the traveling teachers. And when some people did want to help the traveling teachers, then Diotrephes stopped these people from coming to the church. Diotrephes did not allow the people who wanted to help the travelling preachers to remain part of his church.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who could no longer be part of a community? How did this affect their lives? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that some traveling preachers come to Diotrephes with a letter from John. These preachers expect that Diotrephes will welcome them and will let them speak in the church. Act out that Diotrephes reads the letter, but does not want to do what John asks. Act out that other people in Diotrephes' church want to help the traveling preachers, but that Diotrephes does not allow them to do this. Act out that Diotrephes then forces those people out of the community of believers. You can also act out that all this time, the traveling preachers have no place to stay! The preachers go back to John and tell John what happened. Act out how John might have responded. Pause this audio here.

Diotrephes expels some people from his church. This means Diotrephes does not allow these people to continue to worship together with the other believers. These people cannot remain part of the community of believers.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about people who leaders removed from the church? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that Diotrephes expels, or puts out, some people from the church. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 9–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself "the elder"
- Gaius
- Some traveling preachers
- Diotrephes
- And people in Diotrephes' church

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

3 John 1:9–10

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"So, dear Gaius, you are doing a good thing! But unfortunately, Diotrephes is not! I wrote a letter to Diotrephes' church, but he does not want to listen to me. Diotrephes behaves as if he is the boss. When I will come, I will tell the people in the church what Diotrephes has done. I will tell the people that Diotrephes is telling wrong, evil lies about me." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John,"What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I am really hurt because of what Diotrephes has done; or
- I am so sad because Diotrephes no longer has a good relationship with me.

Ask the person playing Gaius, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I am so sad that Diotrephes no longer wants to listen to John. This is very wrong. John is our spiritual father! or
- I am very shocked that Diotrephes is telling lies about John! That is very bad!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"And more importantly, Diotrephes does not allow the traveling teachers to stay in his home. And if some of the believers in his church want to allow these traveling teachers to stay in their homes, then Diotrephes forbids them to do that. Diotrephes even puts these believers out of his church!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- What Diotrephes has done is really shocking. When Diotrephes did not accept the traveling teachers that I had sent, I was very much hurt.

Ask the person playing Gaius, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- It is very shameful that Diotrephes did not give hospitality to the traveling teachers who came from John. I cannot believe that Diotrephes has even expelled some people from the church! This is horrible!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 9 to 10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John says that he wrote something to the church. This probably means that John wrote a letter to the group of believers who together formed the church that Diotrephes belonged to. In the Bible, the word "church" always refers to a group of believers, and never to a building. Sometimes the word church refers to a group of believers in a certain place. Sometimes the word church refers to all the believers in the world together. In this letter, John seems to use the word church to refer to a group of believers in a certain place.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **church**. The word church is in the Master Glossary. The word **believers** is also in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

John says that "if" he comes, he will tell the people what Diotrephes has done. It is not clear if John means to say that he will certainly come or that he might come. Different translations choose different options here.

Diotrephes refuses to welcome the **brothers**. The "brothers" refers to believers, and probably especially to traveling preachers. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in the previous passage for brothers, or believers. That Diotrephes does not want to "welcome" them means that he does not allow them to stay in his house and does not allow them to speak in his church.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Diotrephes does not want to **welcome** the brothers. Pause this audio here.

Diotrephes “expelled” people from the church who wanted to give hospitality to the traveling preachers. This means Diotrephes does not allow these people to continue to worship together with the other believers. These people cannot remain part of the community of believers.

Stop here and remind yourselves how you will say in your language that Diotrephes **expelled** some people from the church.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one part but you liked the way a different group member told another part.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

3 John 1:9–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (702 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (993 KB)

3 John 1:11–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 3 John verses 11 to 15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 11 to 15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

3 John 1:11–15

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 11 to 15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John had just told Gaius about the bad things that Diotrephes had done. Now, John encourages Gaius not to follow such a bad example. People who do good things belong to God. People who do evil things have not seen God. This means these people do not know God. These people do not have a good relationship with God. John had said the same thing in 1 John, his sermon.

John must be thinking about Diotrephes here. Diotrephes has done evil things in John's eyes. Therefore, Diotrephes does not really know God.

John then introduces Demetrius to Gaius. Demetrius probably was the person who was bringing the letter to Gaius. Demetrius may very well have been a traveling preacher himself. So, we can imagine Demetrius coming to Gaius' house, telling Gaius who he is, and giving Gaius a letter from John. When Gaius had read John's letter, Gaius understood that Demetrius was a good person. And Gaius understood that John wanted Gaius to offer hospitality to Demetrius and help Demetrius to continue his journey.

John finishes his letter by saying that he hopes to see Gaius soon. Then John and Gaius will have a good talk together. Then, John gives greetings from the believers who are with John. These must be people from John's church. And John asks Gaius to give John's greetings to the believers who are with Gaius.

This is the last part of this short letter from John.

Stop here and discuss: Can you share something with each other about how this letter from John makes you feel?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 11 to 15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: John asks Gaius not to follow the example of people who do evil.

In the second part: John tells Gaius good things about Demetrius.

In the third part: John finishes his letter.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself "the elder"
- Gaius
- Demetrius
- God
- People who have said good things about Demetrius
- The other believers who are with John
- And the other believers who are with Gaius

John again addresses Gaius as a person whom John loves. John speaks to Gaius very lovingly. John asks Gaius not to follow the example of people who do evil. Gaius should follow the example of people who do good.

3 John 1:11–15

Stop here and do this activity: Think of a gesture that means to do good things. Think of another gesture that means to do wrong things. Select one person to be the leader. This person will keep making gestures. Sometimes he will make the gesture that means to do good things, and sometimes he will make the gesture that means to do evil things. The other people should repeat what the leader does, but only if the leader makes a gesture that means to do good things. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, you followed the example of the leader if the leader did good things. You imitated the person who did the good things. You did not imitate the person who did evil things.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Gaius should not imitate, or follow the example of, a person who does evil, but that Gaius should follow the example of a person who does good. Pause this audio here.

John says that people who do good are from God. People who do evil have not seen God.

Do you recognize that John is using one of his negative-positive pairs here? John says the same thing twice, but once in a positive way and once in a negative way. John often did this in his books, especially in 1 John. Both phrases mean the same thing. Only a person who does good is from God.

To be "from God" and to "have seen God" mean the same thing. These are different ways to say that such people belong to God, that they are children of God. John often likes to use different words to say the same thing.

John says that everybody has testified about Demetrius. If you testify about something, you are saying something that you have seen yourself and know that it is really true. John means that many believers have said good things about Demetrius. These believers have seen for themselves that Demetrius is a good man.

John then says that the truth also testifies about Demetrius. This sounds a bit strange, because truth is not a person who could say anything. But John probably means that Demetrius' behavior itself shows that Demetrius is a good man. Demetrius behaves according to God's true message.

John himself has also seen that Demetrius is a good man.

And so, there are three reasons for Gaius to believe that Demetrius is a good man: all the believers are saying that Demetrius is a good man; Demetrius' behavior is showing that Demetrius is a good man; and John himself also says that Demetrius is a good man. And Gaius knows that everything that John says is always true.

John speaks about himself as "we" in this passage. This could mean that John is talking about himself and the believers who are with John, but it could also just be a way that John is speaking about himself.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that John writes this letter and gives it to Demetrius. Act out that Demetrius travels around and tells people about Jesus. Act out that Demetrius reaches Gaius' house. Act out that Demetrius explains to Gaius who Demetrius is and gives Gaius the letter from John. Act out that Gaius reads the letter and welcomes Demetrius into his house. Pause this audio here.

The end of this letter is very similar to the end of 2 John. John says that he has a lot more to say to Gaius, but that John does not want to do that by writing. At the end of 2 John, John said he did not want to use paper and ink. This time, John says that he does not want to use pen and ink. The meaning is the same: John will not write more, but hopes to speak to Gaius soon. This probably was a very common, polite way to finish a letter.

In John's time, people made paper from the fibers of certain plants. This short letter of John is just the right length to fit on one sheet of paper that people used at that time! And so, John has by now probably reached the end of the page. People used a small stick to write, and they would dip the stick in a bowl with ink.

If needed, stop here and look again at a picture of paper, pen, and ink as people used in the time of the New Testament. You have seen this same picture when you were translating 2 John. Pause this audio here.

John hopes he will soon talk with the people "face-to-face." This means they will be together and can talk while they can see each other. Use the same word or phrase as you have used at the end of 2 John.

John then wishes that Gaius will have peace. When someone has peace, it means that they are well in every way. They live in harmony with God and with each other. In a time when there were conflicts in the church, this is quite an important wish for people! But this was also a common way to finish a letter. When Gaius heard this, he knew that John was finishing his letter.

3 John 1:11–15

John then gives greetings to Gaius from their friends. The "friends" refers to the believers. The believers who are with John wanted to let Gaius know that they are thinking about him.

John also wants Gaius to greet the believers who are with Gaius—the people in Gaius' church. John wants Gaius to greet these believers by name. John wants Gaius to tell each individual person in his church that John is thinking about them and greets them.

We have reached the end of this letter from John, and also the end of the three books from John. We can now say goodbye to the garden in which John has shown us around.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity: Prepare a drama, a song, or another presentation on this whole letter from John, and present this to your church.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 11 to 15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, the writer of this letter, who calls himself "the elder"
- Gaius
- Demetrius
- God
- People who have said good things about Demetrius
- The other believers who are with John
- And the other believers who are with Gaius

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"Dear friend, do not follow such an evil example. Someone who does good belongs to God. But someone who does evil does not know God.

"Please welcome Demetrius. All the believers say good things about Demetrius. Everything that Demetrius does shows that Demetrius obeys God's true message. I myself say good things about Demetrius, and you know that everything I say is always true." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I hope that Gaius will not do the same as what Diotrephes has done. I hope that Gaius will not refuse to give hospitality to Demetrius and other traveling preachers like him!

Ask the person playing Gaius, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

3 John 1:11–15

- I am really glad to meet Demetrius. If John believes that Demetrius is a good person, then I am very glad to let him stay in my house! I look forward to hearing Demetrius preach to us in our church as well!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"I have more to say to you, but I do not want to do this through a letter. I hope to come and see you soon, and then you and I will have a good talk together." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Gaius, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I am glad that John hopes to come and visit us. We will have so much to tell each other!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"May you have peace. Our friends here give you their greetings. Please give my greetings to the friends who are with you, each one of them." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- It makes me happy to think about the people in Gaius' church. I want all of the people to know that I am thinking about them.

Ask the person playing Gaius, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I feel good that the people in John's church are thinking about me; or
- The people in my church will be really happy that John is thinking about them!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 3 John verses 11 to 15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John calls Gaius **beloved**. This means that John loves Gaius. It can also mean that God loves Gaius. Both would be true! Use the same word as you have used in the beginning of this letter.

Gaius should not follow the example of someone who does **evil**. Evil is the opposite of good. A person who is evil willingly does bad things that hurt other people. Use the same word for evil as you have used in other books of the Bible. The word evil is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Gaius should not follow the example of someone who does evil. Pause this audio here.

Everyone has testified about Demetrius. This means that everyone has said good things about Demetrius. Or, everybody says that Demetrius is a good man. If you testify about something, you say something that you have seen yourself and know that it is really true. John does not mean that really everyone in the world has said good things about Demetrius. John means that many believers have said good things about Demetrius.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that everyone has said good things about Demetrius. You can listen to the explanation about **testimony** in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John says that the truth has testified about Demetrius. John probably means that Demetrius' behavior itself shows that Demetrius is a good man. Demetrius behaves according to God's true message. Demetrius behaves according to the gospel. For John, the truth is often another way to talk about the gospel.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that the **truth has testified** about Demetrius. Pause this audio here.

John himself also says that Demetrius is a good man. Gaius knows that **John's testimony** is true. This means that Gaius knows that John always speaks the truth. Gaius can trust anything that John tells him. Therefore, Gaius can be sure that Demetrius is a good man.

Stop here and discuss how you can say this in your own language. Pause this audio here.

3 John 1:11–15

John has a lot more to tell Gaius, but he does not want to **write with pen and ink**. This means that John does not want to keep writing a longer letter.

Stop here and discuss how you can say this in your own language. You can use the same phrase as you have used at the end of 2 John. Pause this audio here.

John hopes to see Gaius soon. Then John and Gaius will have a **good talk together**.

Stop here and discuss how you can say this in your own language. You can use the same phrase as you have used in the end of 2 John. Pause this audio here.

John wishes that Gaius may have **peace**. When people live in peace, they are completely well. People who are living in peace have a complete life and are living in harmony with each other, with nature, and most importantly, with God! Someone who lives in peace is content.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that John wishes peace to Gaius. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in other books of the Bible. The word peace is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The **friends** give greetings to Gaius. “The friends” refers to the believers who are with John; people who belong to John’s church. John wants Gaius to give greetings to the friends there. These are the believers who are with Gaius; people who belong to Gaius’ church. John wants Gaius to greet the friends, each **by name**. John wants Gaius to give greetings from John to each individual person in Gaius’ church.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the friends give greetings to Gaius, and that John gives greetings to the friends who are with Gaius. Do not forget to say that John wants Gaius to greet each of the friends by name.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

3 John 1:11–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (696 KB)
- Setting the Stage (1.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.7 MB)

3 John 1:11–15

- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (993 KB)